

Screen size



When you choose a notebook one of the first considerations is what screen size do you need. A bigger screen may seem like the obvious choice, but notebooks are supposed to be portable right? Imagine the horror of lugging around a 17-inch laptop. However, there may be those who do not need to carry their notebook with them everywhere and for such people a large notebook is definitely better. Such large-screen, bulky notebooks are called desktop replacements; mainly because they sit still on your desktop. Such notebooks are usually of a screen size of 16-inches and above. 17-inch notebooks are the most common.

A screen size of 15.4-inches is considered a de facto size for notebooks although some people regard this size to be a little too large for enabling true portability. 14.1-inch notebooks are soon becoming the new de facto size category for what strikes a good balance between flexibility in performance and size and weight.

The compact segment (aside from netbooks) is generally the hottest category because such notebooks bring extreme portability along with good performance. Notebooks with screen sizes of 11.1-inches, 12.1-inches and 13.3-inches are the most common ones. Generally the smaller the screen gets, the costlier the notebook tends to become since shrinking of size means more attention to other factors such as heat dissipation and actual fitment of components.

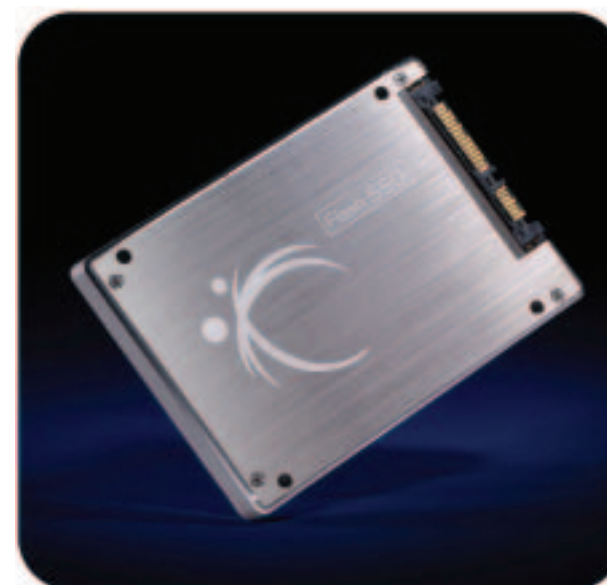
Netbooks are even more compact; although the tradeoff is on component performance and of course a smaller keypad; which may not suit everybody.



Extending battery life

A few notebooks have a dedicated switch for switching between an integrated video solution and the discrete graphics solution. Since an onboard solution will consume one fifth the power this is handy when operating on battery juice.

Laptops



Storage

Notebooks do not use the same hard drives that desktop PCs use. A smaller form factor i.e. 2.5-inches is what is prevalent. Notebook hard drives also come with different spindle speeds; faster speeds mean better performance at the cost of extra heat generation and more importantly possibly lower battery life. The three common speeds are 4200 rpm, 5400 rpm and 7200 rpm. Stay away from 4200 rpm drives; these are a little too slow for most users. 5400 rpm is what you should look at; remember that 7200 rpm drives are better albeit costlier and some very compact notebooks cannot utilise these hard drives for fear of overheating.

Solid State Drives (SSD) is a relatively new technology that has pervaded the notebook space first. The biggest advantage with SSD is the lack of any moving parts which allows SSDs to enjoy very low power consumption and yet have higher performance than any hard disk drive. In fact the read and write speeds of SSDs are three times higher than the fastest HDDs around – a very solid performance increment. The only downside is SSD is a new technology and is very costly. Data density is also not as high as HDDs. The highest capacity SSDs are in the region of 250 GB; these cost fifty times more than a hard drive of the same capacity. However, smaller capacities like 32 GB and 64 GB are a little more affordable and if you want extreme performance and better battery life then you may opt for an SSD storage based notebook. Many manufacturers are offering such drives as optional upgrades on various notebooks.

When it comes to storage there is no ballpoint figure although 160 GB is a good place to start. For real data hogs you may need to invest in a 320 GB hard drive. Opt for a SATA drive if your notebook supports it; Serial ATA is a faster interface. Most notebooks today feature SATA connectivity.